ICONIC STRUCTURES AT SABARMATI ASHRAM



Hriday Kunj: Mahatma Gandhi's residence during his stay here



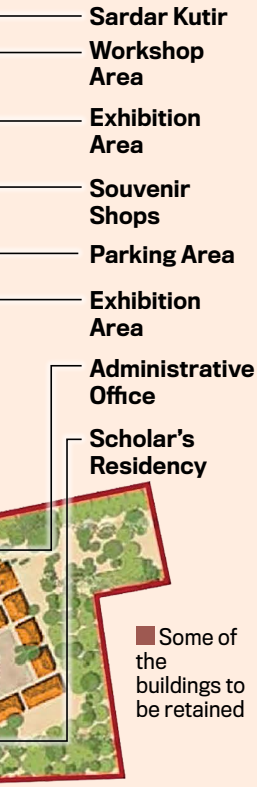
Magan Niwas: Residence of the Mahatma's nephew and one-time ashram manager Maganlal Gandhi



Nandini Niwas: Old ashram guesthouse



Vinoba Kutir: Residence of one of Mahatma Gandhi's followers, Vinoba Bhave



Source: Mahatma Gandhi Sabarmati Ashram Memorial Trust

remain unanswered is regarding the management of the redeveloped premises—the Sabarmati Ashram Preservation and Memorial Trust (SAPMT) currently manages the memorial and museum on the campus, but the Mahatma Gandhi Sabarmati Ashram Memorial Trust (MGSAMT) has been set up as part of the redevelopment project.

The Sabarmati Ashram had served as Gandhi's residence for 13 years, from 1917 to 1930. According to the available records, the ashram then was spread across 120 acres. Today, only five acres remain accessible to tourists, which includes the Hriday Kunj, the residence of the Mahatma and his wife Kasturba, as well as a museum and an exhibition area designed by architect Charles Correa in 1963. In addition to the SAPMT, five other trusts—the Sabarmati Harijan Ashram Trust, the Sabarmati Ashram Gaushala, the Gujarat Khadi Gramodyog Mandal, the Khadi Gramodyog Prayog Samiti and the Gujarat Harijan Sevak Sangh—which have been carrying on the work started by Gandhi at Sabarmati—operated from the ashram premises, before they were relocated, as part of the revamp plan. The plan also saw the rehabilitation of more than 250 families who had come to live on the ashram premises over the years.

The redevelopment project, undertaken jointly by the Centre and the Gujarat government, envisages giving visitors an immersive experience and understanding of life during Gandhi's time. "To maintain continuity in the architectural language, only technology dating back to the time the ashram was built will be used for restoration and reproduction purposes," a source from the design team told INDIA TODAY.

THE PROJECT INTENDS TO MAINTAIN CONTINUITY IN THE ARCHITECTURAL LANGUAGE AND WILL EMPLOY THE TECHNOLOGY USED WHEN THE ASHRAM WAS BEING BUILT

According to the masterplan, the revamped ashram will also serve as a venue for exhibitions on the Mahatma's life, from his work in India and abroad, to the mass movements he launched, his daily routine and important events in his life. The masterplan of the precinct has been prepared by architect Bimal Patel's firm HCP Design, which also designed the new Parliament building inaugurated last year. An area of 322 acres surrounding the actual ashram is also to be developed, to harmonise it with the ethos of the Sabarmati Ashram, but its detailed plans have yet to be released.

The masterplan for the revamped ashram released by PM Modi "is largely based on a concept note prepared by SAPMT", said the trust's managing trustee Kartikeya Sarabhai. Talking about the management of the ashram, Sarabhai said "we are now entering a new phase". Sources in SAPMT also said that the trust, which maintains an exhaustive repository of literature on the Mahatma, hoped to curate the contents of exhibitions at the revamped ashram. Addressing concerns raised by the Gandhian community on the government undertaking the revamp, "bypassing the SAPMT", a source in the ashram said, "Several unauthorised structures, which neither had anything to do with the ashram's activities nor were in harmony with its aesthetics, had come up on the extended campus. To enhance visitors' experience, these structures had to be demolished, public land and roads had to be acquired, and families rehabilitated. This could not have been possible without the active participation of the government". ■